

THE BRIDGE TO DISASTER The collapsed under-construction bridge in Palanpur

GUJARAT

THE PLAGUE OF FALLING BRIDGES

By Jumana Shah

Celebration turned to tragedy this Dussehra in Palanpur town of Banaskantha district in north Gujarat. A section of an under-construction railway overbridge crumbled to the ground, killing two people and marking the latest in a disturbing series of incidents that have plagued the state over the past couple of years. It didn't take long for the issue to get politicised, as political parties traded charges and tried to pass the buck.

The opposition Congress claimed that the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) had blacklisted the firm constructing the flyover in 2017 because the roads it built were washed out in the first monsoon. "The contract was awarded to GPC Infrastructure in 2021 with the knowledge of its dubious operations that exist on government records," Congress Legislative Party leader Amit Chavda said. He also alleged that the company was rewarded for donating crores of rupees to the BJP before the 2019 election. The BJP government refuted the allegations, asserting that the government and Palanpur's urban local body had no role in GPC Infrastructure executing the project. The blacklisted firm was subcontracted by the company that was awarded the contract by the government, says an urban planner who has worked closely with the government for two decades.

For a state that has set ambitious development goals, the spate of bridge collapses raise serious questions about the quality of construction and the oversight of infrastructure projects.

Just two months earlier, in September, during a Ganesh pandal darshan in Rajkot, a concrete slab covering a drain gave way, killing one and injuring at least a dozen from among the 20 people who fell into the drain. Earlier in June, a portion of a ready-to-be-inaugurated bridge over the Mindhola River in Tapi district came crashing down. While no lives were lost, it left the region in a state of shock, considering the bridge was on the verge of opening for vehicular traffic.

As per data compiled by the Congress, the Palanpur collapse is at least the 10th such incident recorded within a mere two years in Gujarat. Worse still, it occurred just a fortnight before the first anniversary of the Morbi foot overbridge collapse tragedy, which claimed 135 lives. Each of these episodes triggered a political storm.

Following a huge controversy, the AMC in September issued tenders

CRASH CHRONICLE

- **In the past 16 years, Gujarat has recorded 17 incidents of collapse of bridges and concrete structures**
- **The year 2022 alone saw eight such incidents**
- **The government is exploring new policies that will prioritise quality over finding the lowest bidder to prevent collapses**